Foucault

Michel Foucault is one of the most controversial and enigmatic thinkers of his time. The controversy surrounding him has more than one cause. He died of AIDS in 1984, and his death attracted considerable attention. Rumours about its circumstances brought publicity which his difficult, sometimes almost impenetrable writings might not otherwise have obtained. Although highly influential in intellectual circles, their influence largely remained within those circles. Despite his political activism, Foucault was principally a product of the academic intellectual world. He was a fascinating Byronic or Promethean figure, in some respects Dionysian and part of the French Romantic tradition: powerful sentiments, strong emotions and a vivid, deep interiority. The cost was a dark side, an affiliation and fixation with death, an almost obsessive interest in power and a powerful critical intelligence. This intelligence dissolved and undermined the claims used to substantiate or legitimize the fields of thought he investigated.

The result of his intellectual work was an anti-humanism, a kind of inverted pantheism that takes Nietzsche's will to power as far as possible. There is no legitimizing metadiscourse for moral or political judgments, or for our estimations of self and society. There is merely power, desire and our relationship to the completely contingent and utterly arbitrary. Foucault's project resembles the stance towards being found in William Burroughs's novels. The resonance between their outlooks can make Foucault more accessible to readers of Burroughs, and Burroughs more accessible to readers of Foucault. Both are outsiders.

Foucault and Burroughs are homosexuals in a society dominated by people who are not. They are also political outsiders, resistant and antagonistic towards established powers. Under the veneer of politeness, legitimacy and humanitarianism, they perceive disguised coercion. Foucault's central message is that extending human freedom requires a ruthless analysis of power, seeking out and trying to eliminate all coercion imposed by one person on another. This might be called a nihilistic philosophy of resistance, or a postmodern articulation of the connection between power and knowledge. His influential investigations concern sexuality, a powerful element in human desire neglected by many theorists, and madness, a remarkable subject for a history of ideas. He also examines the category of the criminal, penology and the history of prisons.

His inquiries gravitate towards subjects overlooked by society and by mainstream historians and philosophers. His life's work also displays a macabre, morbid emphasis on the negative. His personal history is remarkable. Some contemporaries thought he had a powerful fixation on death, particularly after a near-death experience. Having smoked opium, he was struck by a car. As he lost and regained consciousness, he believed he experienced a mystical anticipation of death. He subsequently told those who would listen that death was not to be feared. This dark, nihilistic tendency can be off-putting, but it also heightened his critical awareness, enabling inquiries from which others might have shrunk. He describes their results in lucid, sometimes poetic prose.

One of his most moving and thoughtful statements was that "the soul is the prison of the body." The phrase does exactly what one would not anticipate. Foucault wants to

liberate the body by liberating us from the soul. His early background provides a context for his thought. He received a Catholic education and was remarkable for his brilliance early on.

He was an outstanding student who experienced serious psychological difficulties as a young man. He received psychiatric treatment. The psychoanalyst diagnosed Foucault's problem as homosexuality; Foucault diagnosed the psychoanalyst's problem as psychoanalysis. Such an encounter suggests a prodigy of resistance and little communication, except perhaps a lesson for both about who should deploy which arguments and under what circumstances.

In 1950, he joined the Communist Party, which he left in the early 1950s. Like many French intellectuals, he was on the left, within a tradition of resistance to established powers. Around 1968, the height of the student movement and left-wing radicalism in Paris and the rest of the industrialized world, his politics moved further towards radical resistance. This movement from the red flag towards the black flag of anarchism seems appropriate to his radical reading of Nietzsche, his pointed interrogation of contemporary society and his conception of philosophy as a refusal to be governed in prescribed ways.

Foucault describes his critical stance as a refusal to be governed "like that." Freedom involves refusing ready-made coercive mechanisms characteristic of the cultural tradition into which one is born. It is a philosophy of resistance directed towards extending human freedom. Freedom expands through undermining the social structures that distinguish the transgressive from the morally praiseworthy or acceptable. Foucault interrogates and delegitimizes prevailing moral, political and epistemological codes. He questions the categories of the insane, the criminal and transgression itself. Anything limiting absolute freedom and separating transgression from moral approval appears as a self-imposed limitation. His philosophy declares war on these limitations.

There is a tendency towards intellectual as well as political anarchism. Foucault can be read as Nietzsche's son, almost his distilled essence without the protean variety of his poetic excursions. Other intellectual influences also matter: much of his work borrows from earlier thinkers and does not appear out of a vacuum. There are obvious connections with Hobbes, though books about Foucault seldom mention them. Hobbes conceives human beings as desiring animals, automata pursuing desire, and makes power central to political philosophy. Foucault introduces more complexity and intellectual baggage, but they share fundamental conceptions of human nature and political philosophy's project. Kant is another influence. Foucault does not recreate his elaborate rationalistic structure, but adopts his critical stance towards knowledge and extends it until it delegitimizes the grand narratives leading to the contemporary age.

In this view, intellectual life from about 1800 to 1950 is characterized by grand narratives: one comprehensive story legitimizes knowledge claims, political authority and valid moral judgment. These metanarratives are no longer plausible and must be abandoned. Foucault's conception of critique recalls Marx's call for a ruthless criticism of everything existing. He wants just such a critique. There are also connections with the Marquis de Sade.

Enlightenment critical rationality, without optimism or a sense of moral or political obligation, tends to concentrate exclusively on the self and imprison it within the body.

Like Sade, Foucault is interested in limit experiences and wants to take things to the end. His spiritual stance is Romantic: Romantic poets and writers take powerful emotions, largely set rationality aside and pursue feeling as far as possible. This seems true of both Sade and Foucault. Nietzsche was a major influence. He anticipated a European future marked by nihilism, and Foucault takes up the challenge of driving European culture beyond good and evil.

Foucault absorbs numerous pre-twentieth-century influences and selects from the whole range of twentieth-century French culture, trying to bring these elements together. His inquiries cover an extraordinary amount of ground, including Sorel. Little read today, Sorel defended violence in the early twentieth century. Foucault's interest here need not imply approval or disapproval of violence and terrorism. The connection concerns voluntarism: arbitrary willing towards a political goal without the need, or the possibility, of a legitimizing principle.

This is a key problem with Sorel and Foucault. Heidegger is also important, as he is for many contemporary thinkers, and Foucault's borrowing from him is remarkable. An anti-humanist, Heidegger explicitly tried to move beyond modern ideals of the human and the humane towards a new conception of the subject and interiority. Foucault adopts this approach. His outlook is explicitly and repeatedly anti-humanistic.

Foucault once said that humanism is everything that restricts the desire for power. One must choose between exclusively pursuing power through a Nietzschean anti-humanism and returning to the Enlightenment's moral and political organizing principles, as Habermas does. The latter accepts rational restrictions on the desire for power. A final important source is structuralism, which tends to abolish human agency. Structuralist theories of history, such as Althusser's, turn historical processes into a vast, blind, ateleological machine. Agency is removed from individuals, nations, classes and political, moral or social tendencies. No agent remains.

There is no self, freedom or site of moral responsibility. Things simply are as they are. This structuralist abolition of agency connects with Foucault's project of abolishing modernity, its conception of man and its humanism. These abstract themes become clearer in his major works. Something ironic, playful and perverse in Foucault can also be attractive. His first major book, *Madness and Civilization*, studies madness in the age of reason.

The irony is biting: the age of reason is the age of Kant, Descartes and great rationalist thinkers such as Spinoza. Foucault investigates neither the rise of rationality, the development of natural science nor anything plausibly described as progressive development. He examines madness, particularly its social and linguistic construction. To extend human freedom, he seeks to remove the legitimacy of as many restrictions on it as possible.

Such restrictions include outmoded moral codes and old-fashioned political coercion, but his criticism also reaches nature itself. The limitations imposed by physical natural reality become another object of objection. Extending freedom requires delegitimizing discourses that claim to ground themselves in nature. This is a powerful intellectual move. If someone claims that inequality of wealth in advanced capitalism is natural, one examines the historical development of capitalism and the unequal distribution of wealth. One can show that this distribution did not emerge from nature, but was socially

constructed through contingent historical processes. The argument leads back to madness.

According to Foucault, the age of rational humanitarianism, enlightened freedom and expanding human capacities concealed coercion of the previously free. Histories of asylums and of psychiatric diagnosis and treatment often describe humane, morally desirable progress. Foucault objects: socially and linguistically constructing madness imposed a particular coercion. One part of society imposed its will to power on another, creating a dubious discourse that legitimized confinement in madhouses. Before the Enlightenment's flourishing, roughly between 1650 and 1800, he finds greater tolerance, even a liking for madness. He returns, with some justification, to Renaissance texts.

In Erasmus or Thomas More's *Utopia*, the mad are treated as entertainment or the subject of jokes, but not necessarily without dignity. Madness may be a common human peril, yet there is no special discourse legitimizing confinement on grounds of social utility and taxation of everyone else to support it. The interest in stigmatizing and marginalizing the mad has not yet been constructed in this form. It is a product of the Enlightenment. What is described as the advance of reason, freedom, humanity, justice and kindness becomes a stalking horse for the will to power. This artificially and socially constructed idea of madness is used to coerce particular people for particular reasons.

A connection with Foucault's early experience seems likely. Consider him and his analyst: Foucault was doubtless more intelligent, but their inability to communicate and his experience of attempted coercion probably helped shape his principled refusal to be governed. For all its perversity and morbid elements, this is a courageous and thoughtful philosophy. *Madness and Civilization* and *The Birth of the Clinic* were influential texts. His work contributed to the intellectual environment of anti-psychiatry.

R. D. Laing and Thomas Szasz produced important and fertile reconceptions of psychiatry. Their work developed alongside Foucault's early investigations, rather than simply originating in them. His work proved fruitful and influential within academic circles. He proposes questions that intellectuals find fertile and useful, cross-fertilizing fields where his influence might not have been expected. The movement towards deinstitutionalizing people stigmatized as mad also found intellectual support in his writings and related work. After discussing madness, the clinic and coercive elements in psychiatry, Foucault published *The Order of Things* in 1966.

Its French title is *Les Mots et les Choses*, literally "Words and Things." It is a deep and difficult text; *The Birth of the Clinic* offers a more accessible introduction. In *The Order of Things*, Foucault examines Western thought from about 1500, particularly the human sciences and their changes over time. He seeks patterns of change in economics, biology and linguistics. Analysing their writings and thought, he asks how these fields are socially constructed and reconstructed, and whether their transformations occur simultaneously or are interconnected.

He identifies successive epistemes. An episteme is in some respects analogous to a phase of Hegel's Geist: a particular stance towards the world. It can also be understood as a grammar of interpretation or a conceptual grid, comparable to Thomas Kuhn's paradigms. A paradigm of knowledge predominates at a given time. Knowledge need not be wholly monolithic, but the paradigm covers much of its domain. Foucault

distinguishes Renaissance, Classical and modern epistemes and raises the possibility of a further transformation. Like Kuhn, he emphasizes breaks that are not generated by a logically necessary sequence.

This marks a departure from structuralism, which requires rules for transforming one structure into another. For Foucault, history is not sufficiently organized to provide them. Changes between epistemes are discontinuous and follow no general rules of structural transformation. The result almost parodies Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit*. Hegel seeks to establish the necessity of changes between outlooks: a thesis generates its antithesis, they are synthesized and the process continues.

Foucault offers the opposite. The transformation between epistemes is arbitrary and unpredictable, without a necessary logical correlation between them. Historical changes in human thought do not form a progressive whole and are in principle unpredictable. A slight turn of a kaleidoscope arbitrarily changes the organization of its pattern. Something like this illustrates Foucault's conception of historical change: an emphasis on discontinuity.

He emphasizes disjunction. These epistemological breaks are facts of history, and there is no general formula that makes their operation necessary or predictable. The successive configurations can be described as follows. The Renaissance episteme lasts until about the middle of the seventeenth century. Its organizing idea is resemblance and analogy: making connections between qualities in different things, finding sameness and linking them. It is a relatively simple intellectual move and, for its purposes at the time, a satisfactory organizing principle. With the Classical age, including the Enlightenment, that principle changes, without the change following a necessary logic.

Hegel would seek a necessary logical reason for moving from Renaissance analogy to Enlightenment analysis. Foucault allows contingent historical reasons, but none makes this transition necessary or predictable. Nor does it necessarily constitute intellectual progress: something else comes next. The changes in Western outlook have no internal telos holding them together. By about 1800, the Classical age of analysis gives way to the modern episteme. The middle of the twentieth century appears as a possible turning point, when Foucault and other thinkers associated with postmodernity were reaching intellectual maturity.

In the modern period, roughly from 1800 to the middle of the twentieth century, knowledge, politics and ethical judgment are legitimized through totalizing metanarratives: giant discourses subsuming smaller ones. The Marxist account treats class conflict as the driving force of all history. Political, moral, aesthetic and historical opinions refer back to this comprehensive understanding. Freudian psychoanalysis provides another totalizing metanarrative, a hydraulic model of the mind. The analyst's judgments about aesthetics, ethics or politics refer back to this account, which subsumes and legitimizes other narratives. The issue is not Marxism or psychoanalysis alone, but the demand for an architectonic metanarrative to legitimate local and particular discourses. In this interpretation, the modern world gives way around the middle of the twentieth century to a new phase called postmodernity.

Postmodernity, in this reading, entails abandoning grand metanarratives and legitimizing discourses that refer back to something no longer believed. Moral, aesthetic and political judgments can no longer be legitimized as before. Within the modernist

framework, they cannot be legitimized at all: if legitimation requires reference to a metanarrative, its disappearance eliminates legitimation in the modernist sense. In Nietzsche's phrase, we are beyond good and evil. Foucault's breaks between incommensurable ways of organizing knowledge recall Kant's a priori conditions of cognition. Kant regards certain structures as fixed, permanent and common to everyone: causality, and the forms of space and time. Foucault historicizes these conditions.

He treats them as historically contingent. Within an episteme, certain conceptual structures are imposed, but they are historically determined and socially constructed. They could therefore be socially undone, deconstructed and contingently replaced. We think according to rules, but unlike Kant's, these rules do not remain the same. Such mobility and renunciation of final certainty characterize the postmodern stance. Foucault exemplifies it. At the end of the disturbing *The Order of Things*, he discusses the end of man.

The modern conception of man contains a dualism. On one hand, we are empirically contingent: we live here, at this time, with particular possibilities and constraints. On the other, we assume a transcendental relationship between knower and known. There must be a legitimizing connection between experience and knowledge of the world. Knowledge can be true or false, and some criterion must judge it without being wholly contingent, arbitrary or relative. Modern thought maintains both assumptions simultaneously.

In this account, the end of modernity brings the end of its conception of knowledge, its foundational project and its ideas of legitimate politics and ethics. Its model of knowledge breaks apart. We consequently lose the characteristic conception of the human being that informed modernity from about 1800 to the middle of the twentieth century. Abandoning these epistemological, moral and political projects reveals the contingency of our idea of man. It is recent and could disappear. At the end of his book, Foucault suggests that we may be witnessing man's effacement.

This is not quite a Götterdämmerung but a Menschendämmerung: a twilight of human beings. Once foundationalism, rationally legitimated ethics and rational political consensus are abandoned, the conception of the human being underpinning them must also be abandoned. Foucault thus advocates abolishing the human being as conventionally conceived. *The Archaeology of Knowledge* extends ideas developed in *The Order of Things*, concentrating on discontinuities in discursive practices and explaining his earlier method.

It is primarily an epistemological and methodological work concerned with the structure of knowledge. After roughly a decade of work on these questions, his emphasis changes. He visited Berkeley during the 1970s and 1980s, while holding his chair at the Collège de France. In 1975 he published *Discipline and Punish*, an inquiry into the history of punishment and prisons and the social construction of marginality. His approach to crime resembles his approach to madness: both are socially constructed categories.

These categories refer not to a metaphysical reality, perhaps in the mind of God, but to social practices. The practices are coercive even when apparently humanitarian. Foucault particularly examines Bentham's panopticon. A major utilitarian philosopher of the early nineteenth century, Bentham conceived an allegedly more humane prison

where constant surveillance by the jailer would instil diligence, regularity, thrift, order and discipline. It involves a special architecture of imprisonment and knowledge, with a corresponding conception of society. Foucault criticizes the panopticon and enlightened penology because they unjustifiably limit human freedom.

His criticism reaches the category of criminality itself. A biographical anecdote illustrates the radicalism of this position. When asked to support a movement to abolish the death penalty, he favoured abolition as an extension of human freedom. The argument attributed to him then extends beyond the death penalty to punishment itself.

In this account, he also advocated abolishing punishment altogether, effectively opening the prisons. The proposal may sound like a joke, but is presented as a serious consequence of his position. It is difficult to see what other argument he could make as a Nietzschean. Moral judgment and the political coercion supporting it become the arbitrary will to power of a subset of society. No discourse can legitimize them.

This seems extravagant. Participants in the movement against the death penalty tried to dissociate themselves from him. The point, however, is that Foucault is not afraid to say what others may, with some justice, regard as outrageous. He takes the project of human freedom as far as questioning and abolishing the categories of transgression, the mad and the criminal. He literally intends to go beyond good and evil. A more radical reading of Nietzsche is difficult to imagine.

It is difficult to imagine someone who more thoroughly unifies conviction with practice. At least the occasional achievement of unity between theory and practice deserves admiration. Foucault examines the elements of a perfect penal regime: spatial distribution, control of activity, repetitive exercise, precise hierarchy and the internalization of normative judgments. Essentially, this is a way for capitalist society to create a docile labour force, a mechanism of social control.

Where imprisonment may previously have appeared to possess a real moral foundation, there is now merely social control. In this postmodern interpretation, such mechanisms and their legitimizing projects are no longer intellectually secure. Foucault takes criticism of the outside world and power, and the demand for human freedom, extraordinarily far. *The History of Sexuality*, of which three volumes appeared during his lifetime, moves in the same direction. It questions the sexual, psychological and other categories informing our understanding of sexuality. It also enters territory often avoided by intellectuals: a philosophical history of something so personal and internal. Freud comes close, but the subject is difficult to treat academically.

Foucault examines the social construction of sexuality. If society constructs marginality and sexuality plays a major role in that construction, society also constructs sexuality, criminality and madness. He pushes social constructivism as far as possible. Every increase in society’s power to construct the world decreases the domain of nature, leaving nature less able to dictate to us. In this critical reading, his history of sexuality seeks to establish the social construction of nature, abolishing the limitations imposed by the physical outside world. The method is to question the categories constructing our conception of nature and ask where that conception comes from.

The first volume examines homosexuality, a subject of personal concern to Foucault. He was homosexual and also participated in a sadomasochistic homosexual subculture, showing a particular willingness to pursue transgressive ideas and practices to their

limits. One wonders whether he found the practices themselves attractive or was attracted by their transgression. It is hard to tell: he seems so much a creature of his own construction that his internal inclinations remain difficult to identify. His history of sexuality proceeds through several moves.

First, he argues that the homosexual was invented in the nineteenth century: a modern idea, before which there were no homosexuals. This seems to contradict history. His point, however, is that same-sex sexual activity existed in abundance before 1800, but was subsumed under other categories and understood differently. There were pleasures of the flesh, taking various forms but belonging to one general category.

The homosexual and homosexuality as a category are constructions of nineteenth-century Europe. People of the same sex previously had sexual relations, but these did not yet correspond to the later category of person. The repeated emphasis on social construction seeks to show that heterosexuality, as well as homosexuality, is socially constructed. Indeed, all sexuality is. The domain once called nature is chipped away. A critical reading would describe Foucault's work, like much contemporary French thought, postmodernism and post-structuralism, as a hopeless attempt to evade nature.

Just before his death from AIDS, Foucault completed the second and third volumes of *The History of Sexuality*. They departed from the programme announced in the first. One striking criticism concerns the relatively limited attention to women compared with male experience. Empirically, women are half the world, even if perhaps not for Foucault. A history of sexuality, particularly of its social and historical construction, must consider its biological origins and basis. This would lead into more archaic historical strata than those he investigates.

He largely limits himself to classical antiquity, Greece and Rome. Going further back might reveal that sexuality is only partly socially constructed. There is therefore reason to suspect that he was compelled to restrict his inquiry. When such a protean mind artificially excludes subjects it does not want to discuss or consider, a Freudian might see resistance and a bad conscience. The difficulty may involve not only the lack of time during his final illness, but an inability to address woman and nature satisfactorily. The result is an almost exclusively male and social account of sexuality, skewed and perhaps inadequate: possibly only the prolegomena to a history that someone else will write in another generation.

Several criticisms arise. The most obvious is a powerful tendency towards nihilism. If nothing can be legitimized, liberation and coercion would seem equally acceptable. Habermas's criticism brings this difficulty into focus. The disagreement between their positions poses a pointed question from the Enlightenment.

How can Foucault advocate political reforms, reassess madness, criminality, sexuality and transgression, and affirm public-policy positions while declining to ground them in moral judgments? How can a politics criticize the legitimacy of other positions without explaining its own? Foucault rejected the "blackmail" of being for or against the Enlightenment. The objection nevertheless remains fair to a thinker whose claims sometimes pass beyond evidence and logic. A second difficulty concerns radical historicism and social constructivism. Their advantage is to extend freedom, but they

risk making nature wholly dependent on individual or social wills. Society would have to construct it for it to exist.

Like Dr Johnson’s “I refute it thus,” the objection appeals to material reality: one need not discuss a solid object to kick it. Treating that object and the other elements of nature as entirely socially constructed is unconvincing. Finally, Foucault constructs a Pyrrhonian skepticism dissolving all claims to authority or obligation while mimicking Nietzsche’s heroic style. Because he actually lived this extreme and dangerous philosophy, one may grant him a true Nietzschean heroism.

His epigones, however, sometimes use this approach to delegitimize other discourses while legitimizing their own. Heroic nihilism then becomes a kind of imitative conformity: the discourse of others is delegitimized without satisfactory inquiry into the foundations, or lack of foundations, of the discourse they themselves construct.